MODULE 12

Social Media Crime Analysis

Certified Cyber Criminologist - Police / LEA Training

Samir Raja (CYBER07) | Cyber Crime Investigator & Offensive Security Researcher

What You Will Learn

Social media is the criminal's hangout **and** the investigator's treasure. This module teaches both sides.

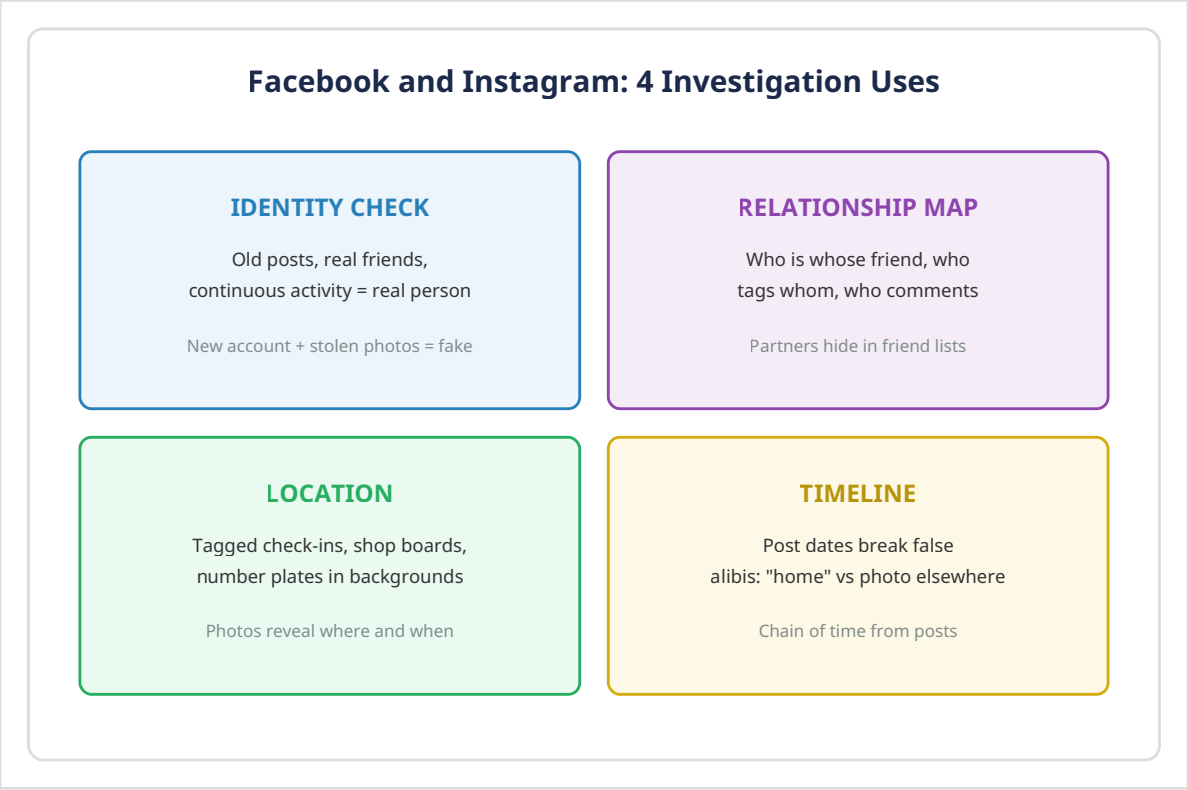
- **Facebook/Instagram investigation** - identity, relationships, location, timeline
- **LinkedIn** - verifying people in company-fraud and BEC cases
- **Safe viewing** - sock puppets and logged-out viewing, within legal limits
- **Legal data requests** - BNSS s.94 notices, nodal officers, MLAT
- **Impersonation and hijacking** - the exact investigation order
- **Evidence-grade documentation** - screenshots, hashes, chain of custody

A Photo That Can Lead to the Criminal

A criminal hides behind a fake name. But he posted **one photo** - and that photo talks:

- The **shop board** behind him names the street; his **shoes' brand** narrows the buyer
- His **friends list** contains people who know his real name
- Three small details - enough for a smart investigator to find him
- People write their own story online; **you just preserve it like evidence**

Facebook and Instagram: 4 Investigation Uses



- A **real** profile: old posts, real friends, continuous activity over months
- A **fake** profile: days old, stolen photos, empty friends list
- Criminals hide partners in plain sight - inside their own friend lists

Identity Verification in Practice

You have only a name, a number, or a photo. **Is the person real?** Here's how you decide:

- Search the name/number/photo across platforms - one real person leaves **consistent traces**
- Check account age: a 'bank officer' whose profile is 6 days old is lying
- Reverse-search the profile photo - a **stock photo or celebrity pic** means fake identity
- Document your finding: screenshot + date + 'appears genuine/fake because...'

Relationship Mapping: The Hidden Network

Who comments, who tags, who is friends with whom - **the network reveals the gang**:

- Map the suspect's friends, then friends-of-friends - partners often sit **one hop away**
- Repeated commenters on a fake profile may be accomplices or other victims
- Draw it as a link chart: circles for people, lines for interactions - the densest cluster is the core

Location and Timeline from Posts

Posts carry **where** and **when** - the two things that break alibis:

- **Location:** tagged check-ins, restaurant photos, signboards and number plates in backgrounds
- **Timeline:** post dates vs the suspect's statement - 'I was home' dies against a timed photo elsewhere
- Build one merged timeline: posts + CDR + transactions - **one story, three sources**

Lead vs Evidence: Never Confuse Them

The most important distinction in this module. **Get it wrong and your case collapses:**

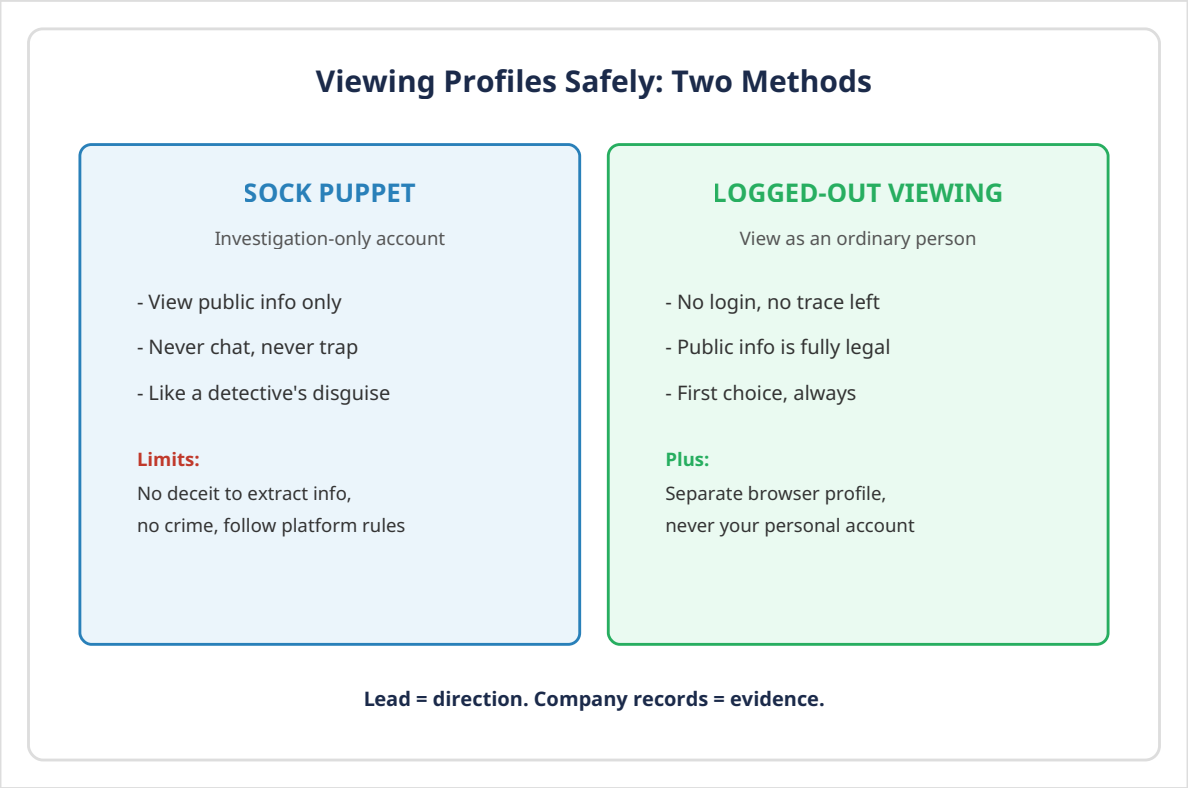
- **Profile information = LEAD.** It gives direction: who to question, where to look
- **Company records = EVIDENCE.** Login IPs, registration data, device info - obtained legally
- A screenshot of a profile **suggests**; a platform's login record **proves**
- Present leads as leads in your report - never dress a lead up as proof

LinkedIn: Verifying People in BEC Fraud

In Business Email Compromise, the criminal **becomes the CFO**. LinkedIn unmasks him:

- Match three things: **name spelling, designation, joining date** - email vs LinkedIn vs company site
- 'CFO' with a 2-week-old profile and 3 connections = fraudster
- Also tells you **how the victim was chosen**: public employee lists are target lists for criminals

Viewing Profiles Safely



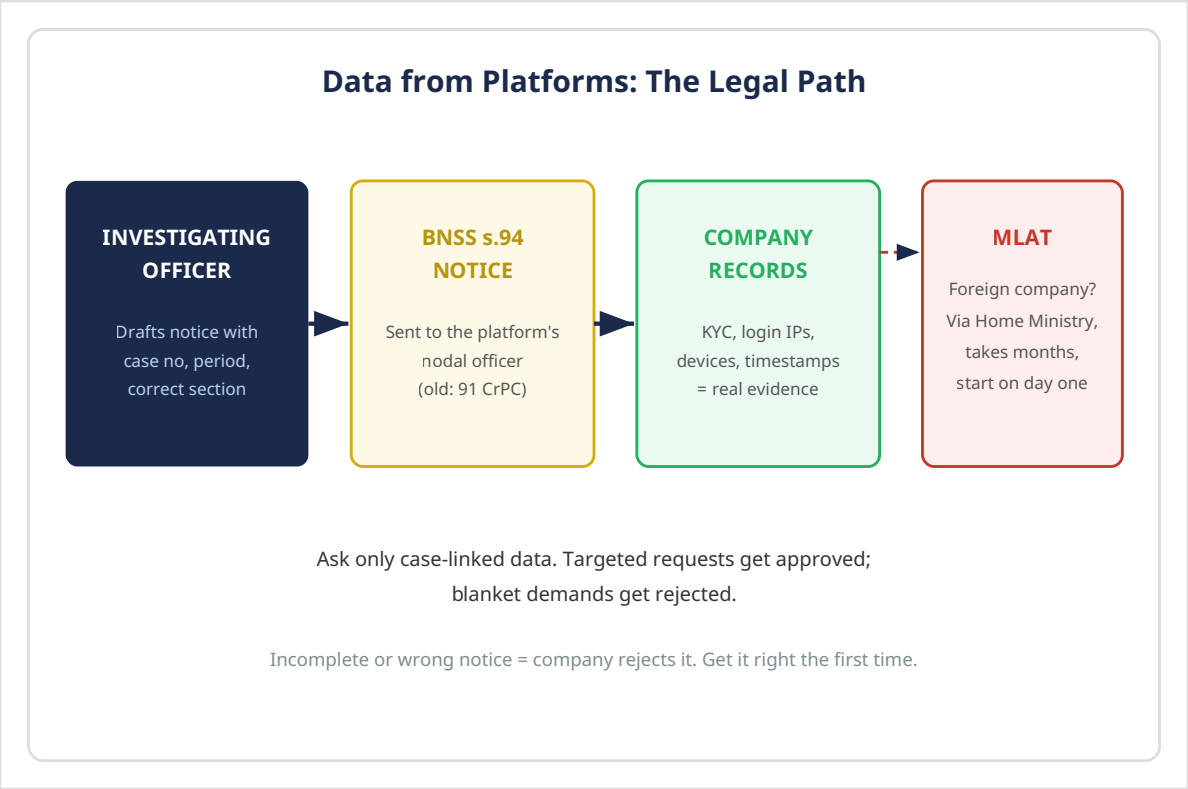
- Viewing from your **personal account** warns the criminal - he deletes evidence
- Sock puppet = **viewing only**; deceit, traps and contact are out of bounds
- Logged-out viewing is always the **first choice** - no trace, fully legal

Protecting Your Own Identity

The suspect must never know you are watching. **Basic tradecraft, every case:**

- Separate **browser profile** for investigation - never your personal account
- Real name, photo and personal details stay **out of the suspect's reach**
- If possible, a **separate device** for investigation work
- One careless view from your own account can burn the whole operation

Data from Platforms: The Legal Path



- Companies hold: registration name, phone, email, **login IPs, devices, timestamps**
- An incomplete or wrong notice gets **rejected** - get it right the first time

Writing a Notice That Gets Approved

Companies approve **targeted** requests and reject fishing expeditions:

- Mention: case number, **exact time period**, correct section (94 BNSS)
- Ask only **case-linked data** - not 'everything about this account'
- Deleted messages and private chats are **hard to get** - know this before you promise
- Draft the notice on **day one** - data retention windows close fast

MLAT: When the Company Is Abroad

Server in the US, victim in India - **this is normal** in social-media cases:

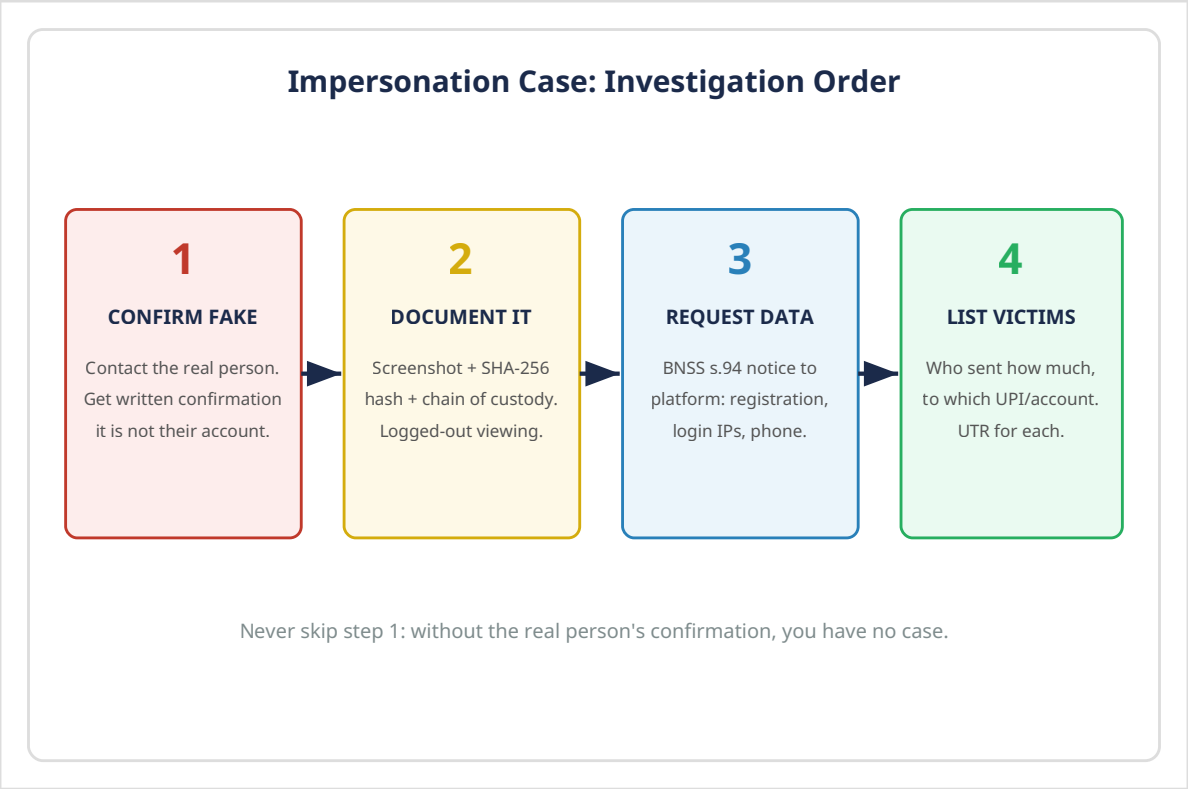
- **MLAT** (Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty): country-to-country legal help via the Home Ministry
- It takes **months** - so file the request at the start, not the end
- Meanwhile, preserve everything visible publicly - **that evidence doesn't wait**

Impersonation: Cheating in Someone's Name

Fake celebrity, fake relative, fake army officer - **trust is the weapon**:

- **Celebrity fakes:** 'I am an actor, send money for charity' - fans pay without checking
- **Relative fakes:** stolen photo + 'my phone broke, send money urgently' to the friend list
- **Officer fakes:** police/army/government - fear plus trust, a deadly mix
- OLX 'army officer' scam ran for **years** - cheap vehicles, advance payment, phone goes dead

Impersonation: The Investigation Order



- Step 1 is non-negotiable: without the real person's confirmation, **you have no case**
- Build the victim list early: who sent how much, to which UPI - with UTR for each

Fake Profile Red Flags



- Score every suspicious profile against the red flags before you act
- One flag is suspicion; **four flags is a pattern** - document each one
- New account + stolen photo + no real friends = investigate immediately

Account Hijacking: The 4-Step Response

Someone's account is stolen and begging money from their friends. **Work in this order:**

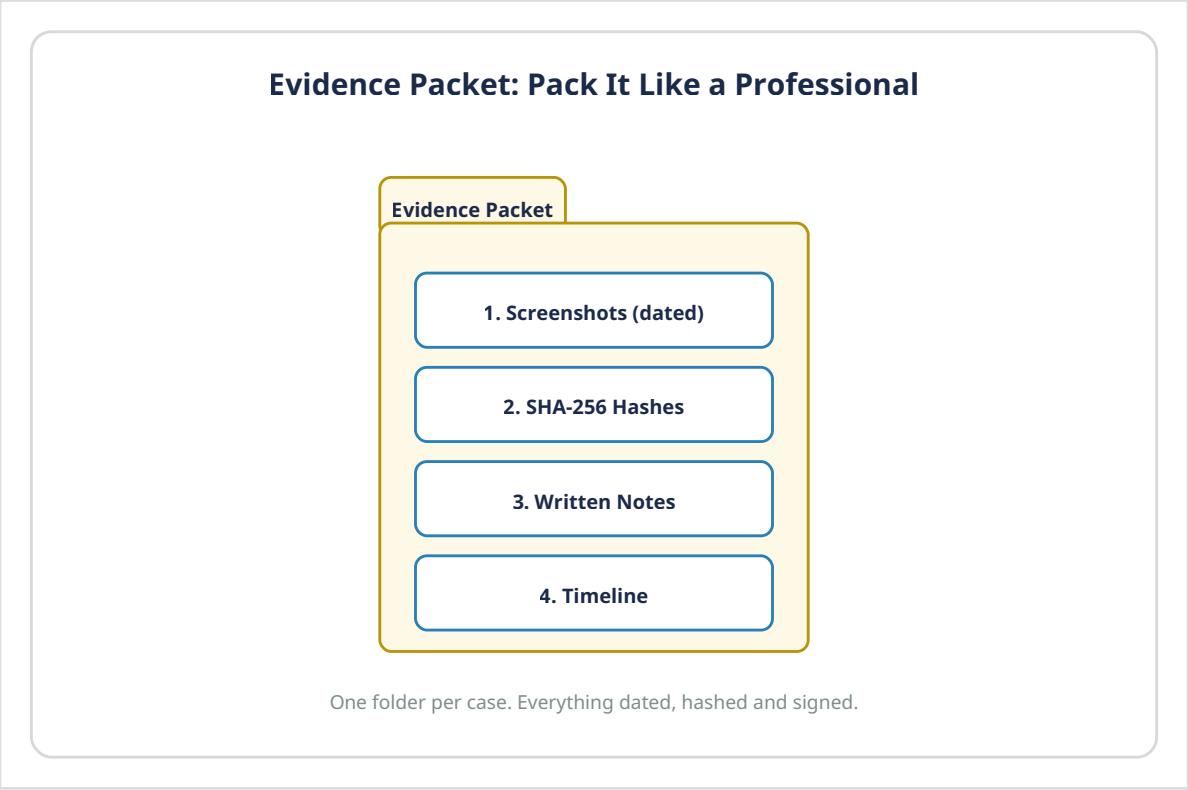
- **1. Spot the alien login:** victim in Delhi, login from another country = hijack confirmed
- **2. Trace recovery changes:** when were email/phone changed, from which IP - the takeover moment
- **3. Follow the messages:** who was asked for money, who paid, which UPI - loss + witnesses
- **4. Recover securely:** platform's official process only - 'hacking-back' services are frauds

OSINT Automation: The Legal Line

Tools can sift thousands of profiles fast - but **speed never excuses illegality**:

- **Legal:** collecting public information - profiles, posts, photos anyone can see
- **Crime:** hacking accounts, reading private messages, breaking passwords
- Respect platform terms: automated scraping can get your account banned and **weaken your evidence**
- Slow, manual, within the rules - always safe, always defensible

Evidence Packet: Pack It Like a Professional



- Screenshots + **SHA-256 hash** of each file + observation note + chain of custody
- URL bar, system clock, full profile visible in every screenshot
- One pixel changed = hash changed = tampering **proven absent**

Real Case: Sulli Deals and Bulli Bai

2021-22: apps 'auctioning' Muslim women's photos - **stolen from social media**:

- Not mischief - a planned conspiracy to scare and insult; promoted on Twitter
- Delhi and Mumbai Police joined fake handles, app-makers' digital marks, money chains
- Young accused arrested. Lesson: **platform data + digital marks + police work** wins
- Source The Indian Express

Real Case: Fake Army Officer on OLX

Years-long fraud: 'army officer' selling cheap cars on OLX - **the uniform sold the lie**:

- Transfer story, fake army ID, uniform photos - then advance 'delivery charge', then silence
- Army's trust made victims pay without suspicion; police issued repeated warnings
- Evidence: advertiser's number, payment UPI, fake ID images - **preserve the ad fast**
- Source Hindustan Times

Your Turn: Labs in This Module

Three hands-on labs - **practice only, never on a real person's profile**:

- **Lab 1:** Document a fake profile like evidence - screenshots, hashes, custody note
- **Lab 2:** Verify a BEC sender via LinkedIn - the 9-point checklist
- **Lab 3:** Prepare complaint drafts in advance - platform report, portal complaint, 1930 checklist
- Ready drafts mean **zero delay** when a real case arrives

Mistakes That Kill Social-Media Cases

These errors turn strong cases into weak ones:

- Viewing the suspect from your **personal account** - he deletes everything overnight
- Treating a profile screenshot as **proof** - it is a lead; company records are proof
- Filing a **vague data request** - 'give everything' gets rejected; targeted gets approved
- Waiting weeks for MLAT while **public evidence** disappears - preserve day one

Key Takeaways

If you remember nothing else from Module 12:

- Social media gives **identity, relationships, location, timeline** - four gifts to investigation
- **Lead vs evidence:** profile info directs you; platform records convict
- View safely: **logged-out first**, sock puppet for viewing only, never from personal accounts
- Data requests need **94 BNSS, case number, exact period** - targeted, on day one
- Impersonation order: **confirm fake, document, request data, list victims**
- Document like court is watching - **screenshots, hashes, custody notes**

Review Questions

- 1. A profile has 4,000 friends but was created 9 days ago with a celebrity's photo. Genuine or fake? Give three reasons.
- 2. Why is a profile screenshot a 'lead' and a platform's login record 'evidence'? Explain the difference.
- 3. Your s.94 notice to a platform was rejected. List three likely reasons and how you fix each.
- 4. Walk through the four steps of an account-hijacking investigation. What evidence does each step produce?
- 5. When is a sock puppet legal, and where exactly is its boundary? Give one allowed and one forbidden use.

NEXT: MODULE 13

Investigation with Splunk and ELK

Logs never lie - search them like Google

Cyber Crime Investigator - Training Manual